

own settings describe third-party cookies as cookies created by other sites whose content is embedded in the page. Blocking or isolating them can reduce cross-site tracking.

Cookies are only one storage method. Websites can use local storage, IndexedDB and other browser databases to retain information. They may also load tiny images or send background requests that report when a page was opened or closed. The Beacon API, for example, lets a page initiate a request even as it is being unloaded. These technologies have legitimate uses, but they can also contribute to measurement and profiling.

Tracking can travel inside links. A long shopping or social-media URL may contain identifiers after a question mark. When you click or share it, the destination may receive those parameters. WebKit describes “link decoration” as adding tracking information to URLs and “bounce tracking” as routing a visitor through an intermediary domain before reaching the destination.

Even after cookies are deleted, fingerprinting may remain. A site can combine details such as browser version, operating system, language, screen dimensions, hardware information, installed fonts and graphics behaviour into a distinguishing pattern. No single detail needs to identify you; the combination may. Also, websites can recognise you directly. Signing into the same account, paying with the same method or submitting the same email address can reconnect activity regardless of cookie settings. Browser privacy cannot undo deliberate identification.

Private mode protects device, not your identity

Incognito or Private Browsing is useful when using a shared computer, opening a temporary session or preventing ordinary history from remaining after all private windows close. It does not make the activity invisible to visited websites, an employer, school, internet provider or another organisation controlling the network. Google states this explicitly in Chrome’s Incognito guidance.

Private modes can include additional protections. Safari Private Browsing blocks known trackers, removes certain tracking parameters from URLs and adds fingerprinting defences. These benefits are valuable, but they still do not make a logged-in account anonymous or conceal every network-level record.

Use private mode for a specific purpose, not as a permanent privacy strategy. Downloads and bookmarks normally remain after the session. Files opened in other applications may generate their own recent-item lists or cloud backups. Close every private window when finished, especially on a shared device. Chrome confirms that files downloaded and bookmarks created during Incognito sessions remain until the user removes them.

Step 1: Create separate browser profiles

Use different browser profiles for major identity compartments such as Work, Personal, Financial and Public. Profiles are more reliable than remembering to log out because they separate history, bookmarks, saved passwords, extensions and other browser data. Firefox’s profile documentation distinguishes profiles, which separate broad browser data, from containers, which mainly separate cookies, logins and site data within one profile.

Follow this setup:

1. Create one profile for each activity that must remain separate.
2. Give every profile a distinct name, icon and visual theme.
3. Sign into only the accounts belonging to that profile.
4. Use separate download folders where documents may reveal identities.
5. Do not connect every profile to the same browser-sync account.
6. Place separate shortcuts on the desktop or taskbar.
7. Close the wrong profile before beginning sensitive work.

Profiles on one unlocked operating-system account are organisation tools, not strong barriers against another person using the device. Use separate system accounts or devices when local access is part of the threat.

Step 2: Turn on built-in tracking protection

Begin with protections included in a current browser before adding extensions.

In Firefox, open Settings > Privacy & Security and review Enhanced Tracking Protection. Standard mode includes Total Cookie Protection, which confines cookies to separate site-specific “jars”. Strict mode blocks more content but may break some websites. Start with Standard, test Strict if you want stronger blocking, and create narrow exceptions only when necessary.

In Chrome, open Settings > Privacy and security > Third-party cookies and choose the blocking level appropriate to your needs. Chrome also lets you inspect stored site data and

